

A Systematic Review of Sexism in Video Games

Jackson SooHoo (Corresponding Author) Geffen Academy at UCLA

Corresponding Author Information

jsoohoo39@geffenacademy.ucla.edu

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Abstract:

INTRODUCTION:

Investigation into the effects of sexism in video games on its users is increasingly relevant given the growth of the gaming industry.

METHODS:

A literature search was conducted across EBSCOhost, American Psychological Association PsycInfo, and APA PsycArticles. Search terms used: “video games AND sexual harassment,” “video games AND sexism,” and “video games AND misogyny.”

RESULTS:

The search resulted in 522 articles with 495 excluded as duplicates, non-experimental or not relevant to the topic, resulting in 27 included for review.

DISCUSSION:

This literature review provides strong evidence for the widespread existence of sexist content and behavior in video games.

Background

Video games are a cornerstone of modern culture, with the *Global Video Game Consumer Segmentation* report in 2020 indicating that over three billion people worldwide have participated in some form of online gaming (1). Sexism in gaming gained widespread recognition with the GamerGate controversy in 2014. GamerGate refers to the movement of people reacting to and sometimes encouraging the severe online harassment of three women from the video game community, which inspired many major news outlets to take a closer look at sexism in the video game industry. (1-2) With the sudden onset of the Covid-19 pandemic in March 2020, the video game industry has experienced massive growth. According to Nielson Games Video Game Tracking, the number of people playing video games in the United States rose by 46% in the first three months of the national quarantine period. Thus, an investigation into the effects of sexism in video games on its users is not only relevant, but imperative. (3)

This literature review provides strong evidence for the widespread existence of sexist content and behavior in video games. This review identified four main topics of study to categorize the current literature and summarize the key findings in each.

Methods

A literature search was conducted across three databases in August 2020: *EBSCOhost*, *American Psychological Association (APA) PsycInfo*, and *APA PsycArticles*. The following search terms were used: “video games AND sexual harassment,” “video games AND sexism,” and “video games AND misogyny.” Search results were limited to only include articles published before August 31, 2021.

The search resulted in 161 articles from *EBSCOhost*, 68 articles from *APA PsycInfo*, and 293 results from *APA PsycArticles*, totaling 522. 98 results were excluded as duplicates, leaving 424 articles remaining. Three-hundred and ninety-seven were excluded as non-experimental or not relevant to the review topic. Examples of results deemed non-experimental were news articles, photographs, and commentaries on existing studies. Twenty-seven studies were included in the final review. (Figure 1)

Results

a. Sexist Content in Video Games

Sexist content can be defined as content which reflects or enforces ideas of prejudice or discrimination based on sex and gender. (4) Four of the included studies examined the manifestation of sexism in video game content. The measurement of sexist content varied widely. Downs & Smith (4) and Lynch et al. (5) measured sexist

content through qualitative evaluations of character portrayals. Martins et al. (6) and Dill & Thill (7) compared portrayals of characters to “ideal” models as well as real-world average measurements of the human body. Disparities between character models and realistic body images in these studies were viewed as evidence of sexist content.

Downs and Smith (4) analyzed the 60 top-selling console games from 2003 and their representations of both male and female-coded characters. These included games from a variety of different genres and intended audience maturities. Researchers discovered that male characters were represented almost six times as often as female characters. Furthermore, female characters were more likely to have unrealistic body images and be presented partially nude and wearing sexually revealing clothing. This study’s results indicate that male characters likely hold a larger overall presence within video games, and when female characters are represented they are more likely to be associated with sexualization.

Lynch et al. (5) provided a more comprehensive and larger-scale approach as they analyzed over 500 games released between 1983 and 2014 which featured playable female characters. These games were randomly sampled from each year, and all of them featured playable female anthropomorphic characters. The study revealed that there has been a decrease in sexualization of female characters since the 1990’s. However, female characters were more likely to be portrayed in a secondary role and wearing sexually revealing clothing than male characters. Lynch et al. also examined genre conventions to a deeper extent. Genres conventionally oriented towards male audiences such as fighting games were more likely to feature sexualized female

characters. Moreover, the physical capabilities of female characters were positively associated with their sexualization.

Martins et al. (6) reviewed the presentation of all female characters in each of the top 150-selling games from 2005-2006, which included console, PC, and tv-based games. The researchers then compared the in-game body measurements of female characters to data from 3,000 American women. The study revealed that in less photorealistic games, female characters' heads are usually much larger than the average American woman's head. In more photorealistic games, the characters were usually skinnier than the average American woman. These findings indicate that many of the top games on average promote unrealistic body standards of women.

Dill and Thill (7) studied similar principles of character roles and body image. Instead of games, however, they examined the six best-selling video game magazines on Amazon.com from January 2006. They studied the image portrayals of both male and female characters. Their analysis upheld results by Downs and Smith (4) as they found that female characters were more likely to be scantily clad and sexualized than male characters. Findings also revealed that male characters were significantly more likely to be portrayed in an aggressive light. This study's results indicate that in addition to sexually representing genders differently, video games may also apply unrealistic personality stereotypes across gender divisions.

All four of these content analyses measured varying degrees and types of sexism through analysis of the characters in each sample of video games. These studies revealed consistent stereotypical implementations of characters or misrepresentations of characters. However, because there is variability in each study's definition of sexist

content and how they measure sexism, future studies would likely benefit from clear guidelines defining sexist content. The clear consensus is that sexist content often exists in video games.

b. Forms of Sexism

There have been two studies (8, 9) examining the concept of ambivalent sexism: in which sexism is classified as hostile or benevolent. Benevolent sexism can seem to promote “positive” stereotypes of women and call on positive stereotypes of men such as protectiveness, but still imposes rigid gender binaries and often places women in a position of dependence on men. This topic merits its own section because the forms of benevolent sexism discussed in these articles widely differ from the conventional model of direct, hostile, or degrading sexism.

Tompkins et al. (8) investigated 11 different playable female characters through the lenses of both hostile and benevolent sexism and found some positive and empowering representation of the female gender. The characters came from games created by prominent video game franchises in the Japanese and United States. The portrayals of some female characters, especially in Japanese games, aligned with “positive” stereotypes of women such as warmth and being deserving of protection. The findings of this study highlight a complexity of sexism in video games. Sexist portrayals may assume distinct forms and enforce distinct stereotypes across different cultures.

Stermer and Burkley’s study (9) researched the association between sexist video games and sexist attitudes. Participants were administered a survey which included questions about perceived levels of sexism in the games they played. They also completed the Ambivalent Sexism Inventory, which measures both hostile and

benevolent sexism using a rating system in which users rate their agreement with various statements. Participants reported playing a variety of genres including action, role-playing, and sports. Results indicated that men who played games deemed more sexist showed higher levels of benevolent sexism. This finding suggests that exposure to sexist video games is related to higher levels of sexism. However, this finding was not consistent for women. One limitation to this study was that there was not a standardized method to measure whether video games were sexist; rather, researchers relied on individual perceptions of the games subjects played.

Although sparse, this research indicates that sexism in video games can communicate a wide variety of ideas and stereotypes, and some forms may superficially seem to reinforce positive stereotypes while indirectly exacerbating the negative effects of benevolent sexism.

c. Avatars

The largest category identified in this review were fifteen studies conducted on humanoid avatars. An avatar is an in-game figure or icon which represents a character, and this section considers research conducted specifically on avatars. This term refers to both player-controlled characters and Non-Player Characters (NPCs). In contrast with the previous sections regarding the incidence of sexist content, this section also focuses on the effects of avatars on players and their behavior.

Gabbiadini et al. (10) conducted a study with a broad approach to the significance of avatars. The researchers studied the effects and meanings of avatars within players of *World of Warcraft (WOW)*, a popular Massively Multiplayer Online

Role-Playing Game (MMORPG) game. A survey revealed that avatars often were influential in developing social identity for many participants. The study's researchers observed that many participants seemed to live through some of their avatars' experiences and their virtual identities overlapped with their "real" identities. This intimate identification could provide an explanation for why players may be affected by the interactions of avatars they are controlling with others.

I. Avatars and Internal Beliefs

Five studies (11-15) demonstrated the effects of sexualized avatars on the internal beliefs of their players. A separate study had conflicting results, detecting no strong correlation (16)

Fox & Potocki (11) studied the impact of overall video game consumption on player beliefs about women. Drawing upon previous research, Fox and Potocki administered their study under the assumption that video games contained objectified and narrow representations of women. They compared video game habits to personality characteristics such as ambivalent sexism, interpersonal aggression, and Rape-Myth Acceptance (RMA). RMA is a test which measures subjects' acceptances of various myths and attitudes surrounding rape. Results revealed a relationship between video game consumption and RMA.

Ferguson & Colwell (12) also conducted a study assuming video games represented female characters in non-diverse and stereotypical manners. They administered a survey about general gaming experiences, a personality traits questionnaire, and empathy test using a rape scenario on over 100 subjects. Results

indicated minimal correlation between exposure to sexualized video game content and sexist attitudes or empathy levels. This suggests sexualized video games may not influence or be related to sexist ideas.

Fox et al. (13) examined the effects of sexualized avatars on self-objectification, which was defined as the practice in which women “treat themselves as objects to be looked at and evaluated”. Subjects created and controlled avatars in *Second Life*, an open world game in which players can interact with others and form identities. Being exposed to and controlling a sexualized avatar led to higher self-objectification in women than being exposed to and controlling a non-sexualized avatar.

Fox, Bailenson and Tricase’s (14) further work confirmed the embodiment of an avatar may lead to changes in self-perception, which was termed the Proteus effect. In an immersive virtual environment, subjects were selected to either embody sexualized or non-sexualized avatars which featured either the participant’s own face or the face of another person. They found women who played with sexualized avatars experienced more self-objectification as well as body-related thoughts. Participants whose avatars were sexualized and featured their own faces were subject to higher RMA. Similarly, Fox and Bailenson (15) studied the effects of female character sexualization and gaze in a virtual environment. Subjects were shown either a character with revealing or non-revealing clothing as well as high or low gaze in an immersive virtual environment. Findings showed both men and women who were exposed to scantily clad, high-gaze female characters displayed more sexism and RMA.

In contrast, Lindner et. al. showed no significant connections between avatar sexualization and self-objectification. In their study, women were assigned to either

play as a more or less sexualized avatar and their self-objectification, body dissatisfaction, and hostility towards a female partner were gauged.(16) *Lara Croft: Tomb Raider Underground* was used for the more sexualized avatar situation, while *Lara Croft: Tomb Raider* was used for the non-sexualized avatar situation. They showed little connection between the level of sexualization of the participants' avatars and their body dissatisfaction or hostility towards female partners.

Dill, Brown, and Collins (17) studied the impacts of sexualized avatars specifically on player tolerance of sexual harassment. Researchers assigned male subjects to play with either sex-coded or control video games characters and measured their responses to sexual harassment and their RMA. Short-term exposure showed correlation with greater tolerance of sexual harassment, and long-term exposure showed positive correlation for both.

Driesmanns, Vandenbosch, and Eggermont (18) studied the effects of sexualization of female avatars specifically on adolescents. Subjects were randomly selected to play a video game as either a sexualized or a control female avatar. Researchers then measured their RMA and tolerance of sexual harassment. Results displayed a positive correlation for both traits in relation to sexualization of the female avatar.

II. Avatars and Player Behavior

Five studies (19-23) investigated the effects of sexualized avatars on the external experiences of their players. Their results indicated a consensus that playing with sexualized avatars increased the likelihood of players to engage in sexually harassing behavior towards others.

Yao, Mahood, and Linz (19) studied the effects of playing sexually explicit video games which featured objectification of women characters. Male subjects first played either a sexually explicit or control game and then were given a survey to measure their sexual thoughts and tendencies for sexual harassment. Subjects who played sexually explicit video games were more likely to have sexually objectifying thoughts about and commit sexually inappropriate behavior towards women.

Burnay, Bushman, and Larøi (20) conducted a study which was able to confirm the results of the experiment by Yao, Mahood, and Linz. They investigated whether playing with sexualized characters affects external sexual harassment by assigning subjects to either play with a sexualized or non-sexualized female character in the fighting game *Ultimate Street Fighter IV*. The subjects would then be given the choice to sexually harass a partner by sending a sexist joke. Sexual harassment was higher towards female partners when subjects played with sexualized avatars.

Behm-Morawitz and Schipper (21) examined the impact of sexualization of an avatar on the harassment (both general and sexual) experienced by both male and female players. While Burnay, Bushman, and Larøi (20) studied the effects of sexualized avatars on the actions of players, Behm-Morawitz and Schipper focused on how sexualization of avatars affected experiences of players. This study defined sexual harassment as any sex-related harassment. Over 200 participants were given a survey about the avatars they used most in the video game *Second Life* and the amount and type of cyber harassment they received. Importantly, the study only examined cases where users adopted avatars of the same gender. Players with female avatars were more likely to be subject to sexual harassment than those with male avatars, although

this was not true when measuring general harassment. Sexualization of the female avatar was associated with sexual harassment, name-calling, and obscene comments among female players. However, researchers found general harassment such as name-calling and obscenities unrelated to sex or gender was not associated with sexualization. Significantly, these observations were only consistent with female avatars; in male avatars sexualization was not associated with sexual or general harassment. Sexualization of the avatar was only related to cyber-harassment for participating women. One limitation to this study was it was unable to cover cases in which users played avatars with different genders or genderless avatars.

Two other studies (22-23) focused on the relationship between avatars and gender stereotypes. In contrast with the previous studies, these did not focus on the body characteristics of avatars. Yang, Huesmann, and Bushman (22) examined the effects of playing with either a male or female avatar on aggression. The two video games used were both violent combat games: *Ultimate Street Fighter IV* and *Virtual Fighter 5*. Over 200 participants played one of the games with either a male or female avatar. They then were given a choice to give a partner who hated spicy foods a portion hot sauce as a way of measuring aggression. Participants of both genders were more prone to aggression after playing with a male avatar, though this effect was much stronger on male subjects.

In contrast, Kaye, Pennington, and McCann (23) examined the impacts of priming gender stereotypes as well as avatar gender on gameplay. Subjects answered questions about their gaming habits and identity and played a casual online PC game

called *Kiba and Kumba: High Jump*. Neither priming explicitly negative stereotypes nor manipulation of avatar gender significantly affected the quality of gameplay.

The study of video game avatars and sexism has drawn a significant interest. Researchers primarily focused on how altering the avatar affected a player's internal beliefs. They defined and measured sexism through portrayals of female characters, which included body, clothing, and role design. The effects of sexualized avatars on self-objectification were disputed, although more recent research seems to suggest a correlation. Most research indicated avatars held an impact on the experiences of the player, particularly through the lens of sexual harassment.

d. *Gendered/Sexual Harassment in Group Play*

The fourth category of research characterized interactions between players in multiplayer scenarios and how sexist behavior occurs in the video game community more broadly. Most studies measured subject experiences through chat and voice call functions as they offer convenient communication between gamers as well as spectators and streamers. Although the previous category of studies regarding avatars also included information about in-game communities, this section deals with the gaming community as a whole. Furthermore, the games mentioned in this section are more popular and have larger playerships. Finally, this section also includes studies about the gaming community outside of playing, such as spectating and streaming. As such, it addresses a much larger sample of the video game community than the previous sections. These studies found strong evidence for the existence of sexism and sexual harassment between players, with experiences likely differing between genders.

There was also a specific focus on finding correlations between different personality traits and engaging in sexist behaviors.

There have been five studies (24-28) conducted on sexism in group play. Three of the studies (24-26) focused on the presence of sexism-related harassment. Holden, Baker III and Edelman (24) documented the abundance of harassment, especially towards women and minorities, throughout the rise of the eSports community. The authors also write about flaws within the gaming community which allow for harassment to continue, such as lack of legal accountability and the inability of social media platforms to properly enforce standards set by their Terms of Service agreements. Fox and Tang (25) supported the idea that sexual and general harassment exists in the gaming community. They recruited active users on forums and social media and administered a survey about their gaming experiences. Their study found women commonly experienced both general and sexual harassment while gaming. They also questioned subjects about whether these incidents caused them to reflect on these incidents at a later time. Results revealed general harassment could lead to withdrawal from the game by women. Sexual harassment was associated with higher rumination outside the game, which could also lead to withdrawal.

Breuer et al. (26) studied sexism in video games through the lens of cultivation theory, which states long-term exposure to media can affect one's views of reality. They conducted a longitudinal study (three years) on the video game behaviors and sexist ideas of over 800 subjects. Results found no correlation between video game playing time or genre preferences and sexist attitudes. Breuer et al.'s study suggests

playing video games in general may hold no correlation with sexism. However, it did not report the extent of sexist content within video games.

Ruvalcaba et al. (27) also validated the concept that harassment is prevalent in the gaming community. Using a questionnaire, their study measured harassment experienced by self-identified gamers from fellow gamers. Both men and women reported encountering harassment throughout their gaming experiences. In contrast with ideas proposed by Holden, Baker Iii and Edelman (24), Ruvalcaba et al. found women did not receive significantly more negative comments from male gamers than men. However, their study did find there were some gender differences in harassment. Each gender received more praise from gamers of the same gender. A second study within the investigation delved into the spectator side of gaming. Ruvalcaba et al. surveyed chat messages received by streamers on the popular video game streaming website Twitch. They selected streamers who played the most popular competitive video games. Female streamers were more likely to receive general positive comments and positive comments directed towards gameplay, as well as both general sexual comments and sexist comments directed specifically at them. There was no significant difference between the number of negative comments received by either gender, and male streamers received more neutral comments.

Three studies (28-30) examined how personality traits were related to a player's harassment behaviors. Tang and Fox (28) administered surveys to over 400 men measuring general gaming habits. Most of the games played by subjects were competitive. The study also measured societal beliefs of participants such as Social Dominance Orientation (a measure assessing one's belief that some groups of people

are superior to others and thus naturally deserve more power, SDO) and ambivalent sexism. Personality factors including hostile sexism and SDO predicted both sexual and general harassment in men. Tang, Reer, and Quandt (29) conducted a similar experiment which upheld many of these results and established new findings. They surveyed the same general gaming habits and personality traits of over 800 subjects. The games played by subjects spanned a variety of genres. Results were consistent in demonstrating SDO and hostile sexism were predictors of sexual harassment while time spent playing was not.

Jagayat and Choma (30) studied the attitudes of self-identified gamers towards their female counterparts. They measured sexism in the community through a survey which asked participants about personal beliefs such as ambivalent sexism and SDO. Participants were also asked to self-report aggression towards women. Although cyber-aggression towards women was low, SDO was found to be a predictor of such attitudes among gamers.

There is a strong consensus that sexist behavior, including sexual harassment as well as general harassment, is common in the gaming community. Some findings also suggest that there may be differences in the type, severity, and frequency of harassment encountered by different genders. The studies considering the relationship between a person's beliefs and their harassment habits consistently show that some personality factors, such as Social Dominance and hostile sexism, are predictors of whether or not subjects will carry out acts of harassment. Much of the research conducted on this topic is observational, with methodology often consisting of subjects self-reporting their personal experiences through surveys and questionnaires. The

research on this topic would benefit from further use of randomized, controlled experiments.

Conclusions

The psychological study of sexism in video games is a relatively new field which has begun to receive increased interest in the past decade. This critical review identified four main categories of research and summarizes findings in each.

First, it is clear that sexism and sexist ideas are reflected in video game content regardless of genre. This sexism can manifest in numerous forms including character design and self-portrayal. Female characters in particular have been created to reflect unrealistic body images and are often sexualized.

Second, sexist content can manifest in less hostile and more benevolent forms such as gendered differences in the roles characters play, with female characters being more likely to be in secondary roles.

Third, the sexualization of avatars may impact beliefs such as self-objectification as well as player behaviors such as aggression and harassment.

Fourth, it is evident that sexism exists in the video game community and often manifests as harassment in group play. Examples have also been found outside of games, where streamers are subjected to sexist harassment by spectators.

Future research would benefit from a clearer definition of terms such as sexual harassment and what constitutes sexualization. Although many of these studies refer to these terms, their designs widely differ on what they consider to fall under each category and often studies do not explicitly state their criteria for judgement. As the

video game community continues to expand, further research is imperative to better understand the impacts of video games on their players.

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Figure 1: Flow Chart of Article Review

522 results across **EBSCOhost**,
PsycArticles, and **PsycInfo**
appear for terms "**video games**
AND sexism," "**video games AND**
sexual harassment," or "**video**
games AND misogyny"

98 results excluded as
duplicates

424 reviewed for content

397 results excluded as
not relevant or not
scientific articles

27 articles included for
final review

